

Startup Idea Evaluation — One Pager

When ANY new idea comes in, run it through this pipeline. No skipping. No shortcuts.

⚡ The Kill Checklist (30-Second Scan)

If ANY answer is **YES** → Pivot or Kill. Don't fall in love.

#	Question	Kill If...
1	Is the pool < 10,000 users in India?	Yes
2	Is the pain "nice to have," not "I'm bleeding"?	Yes
3	Can someone copy this in < 3 months?	Yes → it's a feature
4	Is unit EBITDA permanently negative?	Yes
5	Does the 2027 agent version NOT make sense?	Yes → requires human attention forever
6	Do YOU have zero unfair advantage? (no domain, data, connections)	Yes
7	Does it require full-time quit BEFORE revenue signal?	Yes

🔄 The 7-Step Traversal Engine

1. Pain Point Check

- Who is the primary user? Secondary?
- How big is the pain? (time / money / security / disaster)
- Simple enough for the lamest user?
- Pool size: at least 10% ready to pay?
- Who is the ICP? (age, geo, spending culture)
- Competitor TAM reach: is space left?

2. Idea Pattern Match

Run against proven templates:

Pattern	Dopamine Hit	Hidden Revenue
Zerodha	Profit cliffhangers	Data moat → internal monetization
Slice	Credit for underserved youth	High-interest backend (20-30%)
PocketFM	Content cliffhangers + coin psychology	Low COGS India ops, global revenue

Kill: No dopamine hit + no hidden revenue → feature, not business.

3. Blueprint Validation (Manav Garg's 7 Steps)

1. **Boring industry?** Fat slow incumbents, old software, high existing spend
2. **2027 vision?** AI has memory, voice, agents talk to agents — what does this look like?
3. **What collapses?** Search → Browse → Decide → Purchase → Use → Support — which steps disappear?
4. **One root problem.** Not 10 symptoms. 1 disease. (Doctor thinking)
5. **Lead time test:**
 - < 3 months → Don't build
 - 6-12 months → Risky, move FAST
 - 2-3 years → Good (data moat, network effects, regulatory moat)
6. **Economics check:** Revenue/user vs LLM/API cost/user. Negative gross margin?
7. **Agent version:** Customer agent + product agent talk to each other. If product requires human attention → obsolete in 2-3 years.

4. Feasibility + Bird View P0

P0 — ALL must pass:

- ☐ **Capital** — 50% real costs, 30% meaningful, 20% contingency
- ☐ **Political/regulatory** — approvals? corruption overhead?
- ☐ **Network** — who do you need to know?
- ☐ **Quality** — deliverable at this price point?
- ☐ **EBITDA** — negative at unit level → don't start
- ☐ **Market size** — TAM in India? global pivot potential?
- ☐ **Team** — who's building? selling? managing?

P1 — validate after P0:

- Timing: driving force now / past / next 5 years?
- Global comparison: Israel, USA, UK, China — what constraints exist only in India?

5. PPP Framework

Direction matters: Pool → Pattern → Platformize. Never reverse.

- **POOL:** Addressable behavior pool size? Digitally measurable? Target ONE segment first.
- **PATTERN:** Recurring measurable behaviors? 80/20 time waste? Triggers? Validated with real data?
- **PLATFORMIZE:** Patterns encoded into reusable system? Anyone can leverage without understanding complexity? Cold start approach?

Kill: Pool unmeasurable OR patterns are pure hypotheses → stop. Go talk to users.

6. Pipeline Execution

Identify market → Validate pool → Build addictive UI → Engineer infra
→ Acquire users → Convert 1-5% to paid → Ensure payments
→ Increase reliability → Create barrier to entry

- **AHA moment** — what converts free → paid?
- **Revenue model** — exponential (risky, ownership) vs linear (stable)
- **B2B vs B2C** — B2C = volume, fast pivot. B2B = trust, high ticket.
- **Moat** — data, distribution, regulatory, network effects, switching costs

7. Marketing & Distribution

UNLOCK: Only after Quality + AHA moment are validated.

Phase	Timeline	Action
1. Influencer	Month 1-6	\$10-20K/mo, broad adjacent categories, NO scripts
2. Brand	Month 4-8	Positioning, identity, trust layer (especially B2B)
3. Performance	Month 6+	Only after persona + brand are clear

Critical metric by month 4-6: 50%+ customers from word-of-mouth. If not → product isn't AHA enough. Fix product, not marketing.

The Distribution Truth

Quality + AHA without distribution = great product nobody knows. Distribution without Quality + AHA = burning money on a leaky bucket. Both must be true **SIMULTANEOUSLY** for scale.

Source Notes in This Vault

Step	Source File
Kill Checklist	knowledge_base/rules.md
Pain Point	catalog/1_pain_point/main.mdx
Competitors	catalog/1_pain_point/1.1_competitors/main.mdx
Blueprint	vc/ideas/blueprint_for_hunting_market_in_ai_space.mdx
Feasibility	feasibility/main.mdx
Evaluation Params	parameters/main.mdx
AHA Moment	parameters/p0.mdx
PPP Framework	knowledge_base/learnings/general/Pool → Pattern → Platformize
Pipeline	knowledge_base/learnings/pipeline-for-startups.md
Psychology	knowledge_base/psychology/lame-man-psychology
India Context	knowledge_base/Market working_1.mdx

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